

Session 16: How Hebrew Parallelism Works

Key Takeaways

- Biblical authors often use parallelism in their poetry, which causes the readers to place two or more things in comparison with each other to show their relation.
- At its root, parallelism is a form of comparison and analogy. It assumes that to truly understand and experience a thing, you need to grasp not only that thing but also another thing that is both similar and distinct at the same time.
- Parallelism employs comparison techniques such as analogy, complement, contrast, and sequence—each requiring and aiding the reader to discover the uniqueness and meaning behind the poetic lines.

Poetic Conventions in Ancient Israel

The ancient Israelite poetry preserved for us in the Bible doesn't fit any kind of master system like meter (though some think so). However, the Israelites were aware of a certain kind of speech that was poetic, dense, and distinct from normal speech. They even have vocabulary for it.

- Song (Heb. *shir* / *shirah*): "Then Moses and the Israelites sang this song ..." (Exod. 15:1)
- Psalm (Heb. *mizmor*): "A *mizmor* of David" (Psalm 3; many psalms have these headings)
- Lament (Heb. *qinah*): "David lamented this *qinah* over Saul and Jonathan" (2 Sam. 1:17)

These compositions show a unique, cultural form of Hebrew poetry that is not a formal system but a series of characteristics.

"The Verse of the Hebrew Bible is strange
The meter of Psalms and Proverbs perplexes
It is not a matter of number,
No counting of beats or syllables
Its song is a music of matching,
Its rhythm a kind of paralleling
One line makes an assertion;
The other part expresses in other words
Sometimes a third part will vary yet again."

Hollander, John (2001). [*Rhyme's Reason, A Guide to English Verse*](#). Yale University Press. 26.

Rhythm and Free Verse

Hebrew poetry is shaped into a line-rhythm or verse. It is not metrical (based on syllable counts), but a form of free verse composed of poetic lines.

- Verse = a description of poetic form: "A succession of words arranged according to natural or artificially created rules, forming a complete line; a verse is one of the lines of a poem or a piece of versification" (Oxford English Dictionary).
- Line = The smallest segment of poetry, consisting of a dense, complete statement. People have proposed many words to describe the poetic line (stich, colon, verse, membrum), but "line" is the most simple and common English word.

"The poetry of the Hebrew Bible is a natural, free, and rhythmic system. The poems have no consistent metrical scheme, and so have a freedom from predetermined arrangements. But their language is organized so as to create impressions and fulfill the functions of poetic rhythm. Free verse is totally free, it is verse, but it's free to play with the verse rhythm in a variety of ways, making use of all manner of linguistic artistry."

Dobbs-Allsopp, F.W. (2015). [*On Biblical Poetry*](#). Oxford University Press. 120-121.

The line in Hebrew poetry is most often (1) a complete sentence or subordinate clause (2) consisting of three to five words (3) marked by repetition and clear end-stop signals.

For example, take a look at Psalm 51.

Psalm 51:1-4 NASB

¹ Be gracious to me, O God, according to your lovingkindness;
according to the greatness of your compassion blot out my transgressions.
² Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity
and cleanse me from my sin.
³ For I know my transgressions,
and my sin is ever before me.
⁴ Against you, you only, I have sinned
and done what is evil in your sight,
so that you are justified when you speak
and blameless when you judge.

Parallelism

In *Lectures on the Sacred Poetry of the Hebrews* and his commentary on Isaiah, Robert Lowth created the first comprehensive synthesis of features in biblical poetry (Lowth, 2004).

"There is a certain conformation of the sentences, which is chiefly observable in those passages which frequently occur in Hebrew poetry, in which they treat one subject in many different ways, and dwell upon the same sentiment; when they express the same thing in different words, or different things in a similar form of words: and since this artifice of composition seldom fails to produce an agreeable and measured cadence, we can scarcely doubt it must have imparted to their poetry an exquisite degree of beauty and grace."

Lowth, Robert (2004). [*Lectures on the Sacred Poetry of the Hebrews*](#). Kessinger Publishing.

“The correspondence of one verse or line with another, I call Parallelism. When a proposition is delivered, and a second is subjoined to it, or drawn under it, equivalent, or contrasted with it, in sense; or similar to it in the form of grammatical construction; these I call parallel lines; and the words or phrases answering one to another in the corresponding line, I call parallel terms.”

Lowth, Robert (2021). [*Isaiah*](#). HardPress Limited. 14.

There are many diverse types of parallel relationships. It causes us to place two or more things in comparison with each other so that their uniqueness and meaning becomes more visible after the comparison.

Comparison/Analogy

The corresponding words and images are meant to stimulate imaginative reflection on the shared metaphorical attributes of the paired items.

Psalms 33:6 NASB*

By **the word of Yahweh** the heavens were made,
and by **the breath of his mouth** all their host.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 44:3 NASB

For **I will pour out water** on the thirsty land,
and **streams** on the dry ground;
I will pour out my Spirit on your offspring
and **my blessing** on your descendants;

Contrast

The corresponding words and images stimulate imaginative reflection on the differences highlighted by the contrast.

Proverbs 10:11 NASB

The mouth of the righteous is a fountain of life,
but **the mouth** of the wicked conceals violence.

Complement

The second line complements the first in a general way, to complete a thought or image, or to heighten the point in some way.

Psalms 133:1 NASB

Behold, **how good and how pleasant** it is
for **brothers to dwell together** in unity!

Habakkuk 3:2 Instructor's Translation

LORD, I have heard the report about you; I fear.
Yahweh, **renew your work** in the midst of the years,
in the midst of the years **make it known**;
in wrath remember mercy.

Sequence

The lines are not strictly parallel but develop a short narrative sequence.

Psalms 31:1 NASB*

In you, Yahweh, I have taken refuge;
let me never be ashamed;
in your righteousness deliver me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 31:22 Instructor's Translation

As for me, I said in my alarm,
"I am cut off from before your eyes";
however, you heard the voice of my petition
when I cried to you.

Proverbs 4:10 NASB

Hear, my son, and accept my sayings
and the years of your life will be many.

For a longer example, take a look at Psalm 32.

Psalms 32:1-7 NASB*

- ¹ How fortunate the one whose transgression is forgiven,
whose sin is covered!
- ² How fortunate the one to whom Yahweh does not impute iniquity,
and in whose spirit there is no deceit!
- ³ When I kept silent, my body wasted away,
through my groaning all day long.
- ⁴ For day and night your hand was heavy upon me;
my energy was drained,
with the heat of summer.
Selah.
- ⁵ I acknowledged my sin to you,
and my iniquity I did not hide;
I said, "I will confess my transgressions to the LORD;"
and you forgave the guilt of my sin.
- ⁶ Therefore, let everyone who is godly pray to you

in a time when you may be found;
surely in a flood of great waters
they will not reach him.
7 You are my hiding place;
you preserve me from trouble;
you surround me with songs of deliverance.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Function of Repetition and Double-Poetic Expression

This “speaking in pairs” creates opportunities to use multiple words and images to communicate one core idea from many angles. This type of poetic style is a wonderful way to express complex thoughts through pairing words and images in order to communicate more through juxtaposition.

The biblical authors developed vocabulary for this technique. The Hebrew word *mashal* (משל) means “comparison, analogy, proverb.”

“The parallel lines of biblical poetry are like a pair of binoculars. Some centuries, the lenses of a field glass were set in cylinders that could be slid in and out, but they remained in a single tube. The lookout on a ship looked through it with one eye. Today’s field glass is a binocular: we look through two cylinders, with both eyes, so that we have the advantage of seeing depth. Our eyes, with or without binoculars, see ‘in stereo.’ The effect results from the fact that one eye has a slightly different angle than the other, and so produces a minimally different image. These two pictures are easily superimposed and assembled into one image inside our brain. Biblical parallelism does something comparable: this poetic device creates two subtly different images with two lines that are to be associated through parallel expression. It allows us an opportunity to consider both pictures separately, and then let them sink in together ... The point of similarity between two parallel lines is their very difference! Only those who look closely and have patience will discover and savor the role played by dissimilarity, its surprises, and its richness of meaning.”

Fokkelman, J.P. (2001). [*Reading Biblical Poetry*](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 8-79.

Psalm 62:11-12a Instructor’s Translation

11 One thing God has spoken
two things I have heard:
that power belongs to God,
12 and covenant loyalty is yours, O LORD.

Reflection Question

What would you say is the benefit of communicating with parallelism? What does it do that narrative and discourse do not?